



RABRI IS SECOND ONLY TO LALU AS THE RJD'S CHIEF CAMPAIGNER

assistance from him. No wonder, she comes a close second to Lalu in the RJD list of the most wanted star campaigners. Her campaign tours also hold crucial significance because unlike Lalu, she is on nobody's hate list. She is an elder sister to common villagers. And her appeal apparently cuts across caste affiliations.

Clearly, the housewife has over the years transformed into a deity of fire. A huge makeover for someone, who had tears in her eyes when she took oath as Bihar chief minister in July 1997. There was a time when RJD chief Lalu had to prod Rabri to stick her hand out of the helicopter window and wave to the crowd after addressing public meetings. She always used to resist and recoil. Today, she uses a

THOUGH LALU'S PERSONA STILL INFLUENCES RABRI IN EVERY THING THAT SHE DOES, SHE HAS CLEARLY EMERGED FROM HIS SHADOW.

Kumar likes the sobriquet '*sushashan babu*'. "But where is the change? Name one," she asks matter-of-factly, as the crowd fumbles for an answer. And she always succeeds in getting the message across as she vents her lungs for "Laluji and the coalition partner".

On the face of it, the caste arithmetic may be to the advantage of the RJD-LJP alliance but the JD(U)-BJP combine is stronger than what they were in 2004 when the UPA alliance partners walked away with 29 Lok Sabha seats from Bihar. In 2004, while the RJD-led combine had polled 43.35 per cent (RJD 30.67, LJP 8.19, and Congress 4.49) of the votes, winning 29 seats,

the NDA had bagged only 36.93 per cent (JD-U) 22.36 and BJP 14.57). Even the strongest of RJD supporters concede that history is unlikely to repeat itself this time around.

Beyond crass political equations, Rabri's transformation, however, surely stands out in the highly polarised world of Bihar identity politics. Though Lalu's persona still influences Rabri in everything that she does, Bihar's first and the only women chief minister so far seems to have carved an individual space for her—out of Lalu's towering shadows. Almost.

Rabri now seems to complement and support Lalu more than seeking

separate helicopter and campaigns alone. Times have changed. From her "good riddance remark" defending Lalu over Sadhu Yadav's ouster from the party to campaigning alone in the badlands of Bihar, leaving *saheb* to accompany Ram Vilas Paswan.

Cries of "Rabri Devi zindabad!" rise from the fields, as her helicopter arrives at Ujiarpur. Garlands are presented to her, which she accepts with humility, mildly cautioning her supporters who practically stampede to touch her feet. Soon she settles down on the dais, ready to deliver more of the same soundbites she is becoming fast associated with. ■